

The latest trends in virtualisation

Increased percentage of virtualised workloads: One of the trends that the Indian virtualisation industry is witnessing is the increasing workload that customers are virtualising. Nagarajan says, “I have been around in this industry for quite some time now, from the days when we had to literally struggle to make customers aware about the benefits of virtualisation. From such a scenario, we moved to a phase when customers started virtualising a few workloads for test and development; and today, I am glad to share that we have customers who have virtualised all the way from 50 per cent to around 80-90 per cent of their data centres. In fact, there are a few customers who are 99-100 per cent virtualised. The trend we are seeing is that customers are comfortable increasing the percentage of workloads that are virtualised.”

Business-critical applications go the virtualisation way: Bhaskar Jayakrishnan, director, Software Development, Computing Systems Product Group, Cisco, talks of the virtualisation trends in the domain of business critical applications. He says, “The other trend that we are observing (which is also the reason behind the emergence of the first trend) is the virtualisation of business critical applications. Gone are the days when customers would virtualise only those applications that are less critical. The companies used to virtualise only the applications that IT was very confident about. They never touched the applications owned by businesses, like ERP and mail messaging.

“Some of these applications are extremely critical to organisations and they were not virtualised a few years ago. But now a number of customers are coming forward to virtualise their business critical applications like SAP, Oracle Business Suite, etc. There were never any security-related fears for these applications. Organisations worried about whether the critical application would run the same way on a virtual platform as it did on a physical platform, and whether its performance would suffer. We have addressed most of these concerns now, and there are enough ways to prove that your performance is not going down. You get the same performance and, in some cases, it is even better—if you make the best use of the platform. Most vendors today are virtualisation friendly.”

Migration of workloads from UNIX to x86 environments: Arun Kumar, general manager, Red Hat India, says, “India is a UNIX rich country, in the sense that we have a lot of UNIX deployments in India, compared to other countries. These days, we are seeing a number of customers (thanks to the high cost of maintenance, growing complexity, and so on) trying to move away from their legacy UNIX environments to the x86 environment.”

SMBs are getting virtualisation-friendly

Most companies offering virtualisation solutions have

customised offerings for SMBs. In fact, this is a very important segment for a majority of companies. Nagarajan emphasises, “Virtualisation in the world of SMBs is growing by leaps and bounds. This sector will continue to be our focus area this year as well. Some of our offerings are strictly dedicated to SMBs, and we are constantly trying to make them more affordable. The word SMB implies different things to different companies but for VMware, SMBs are companies that are not necessarily small but whose IT infrastructure may be small or medium—for instance, a large textile firm could have a large business volume, but we might classify it as an SMB from the IT infrastructure point of view. There is a lot of traction amongst the SMBs and SMEs for virtualisation. Let me give you an example. Disaster Recovery (DR) is generally associated with large customers with big data centres. Not many small companies go beyond a certain point when it comes to scaling up their IT infrastructure, as it is expensive and complex. But we all know that IT is critical for any company, whether it is small or big. A lot of small companies were not able to afford the expensive DR solutions previously. So starting this year, we have included the replication part which is used for DR as a free component in our existing licences. As a result, even SMB customers will be able to replicate their data and servers from one location to the other. So this is just one example.

“The other important example revolves around back-ups, which are critical to every customer, be it an SMB or an enterprise. So we have included a back-up solution in our licences, free of cost. This is an issue that every SMB faces. They are not able to afford more expensive back-up software, so a part of the back-up solution is included in our package,” he adds. So the belief that virtualisation is not meant for SMBs and is only for bigger companies is gradually fading away.

Karnick adds, “First of all, nobody implements a technology just for the sake of it. People implement technologies to address their business problems. Most customers spend a majority of their time and budget in solving their existing problems, which leaves them with very little time and money to focus on newer innovations that can help them grow. Typically, the function of IT is to keep things moving. Thankfully, due to virtualisation, a lot of these problems are resolved and the IT team is now able to think beyond the regular issues and take a step ahead in the direction of innovation.” 

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